The Negro Speaks of Rivers

Langston Hughes · 1921

Source: Langston Hughes, 'The Negro Speaks of Rivers,' The Crisis (June 1921), text via the Poetry Foundation. Published 1921; public domain in the United States. Complete text.

> Written when Hughes was seventeen, this landmark poem of the Harlem Renaissance links the depth of Black identity and history to the world's great rivers — from the Euphrates and Nile to the Mississippi.

I’ve known rivers:
I’ve known rivers ancient as the world and older than the flow of human blood in human veins.

My soul has grown deep like the rivers.

I bathed in the Euphrates when dawns were young.
I built my hut near the Congo and it lulled me to sleep.
I looked upon the Nile and raised the pyramids above it.
I heard the singing of the Mississippi when Abe Lincoln went down to New Orleans, and I’ve seen its muddy bosom turn all golden in the sunset.

I’ve known rivers:
Ancient, dusky rivers.

My soul has grown deep like the rivers.

Words to know

Euphrates — river of ancient Mesopotamia, one of the earliest civilizations

lulled — soothed gently to sleep

bosom — chest or breast; here, the river’s broad surface

dusky — dark-colored, echoing both dusk and dark skin